

Bosnia Holds Elections as Leader Declares Victory for His Party

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-04 3 min read

Voters in Bosnia and Herzegovina chose their leaders on Sunday. The **election** was shaped by money worries, the country's hopes of joining the **European Union**, and divisions between **ethnic groups**. These divisions date back to a war in the early 1990s.

Milorad Dodik is a Bosnian Serb **nationalist** politician. He declared victory for his party. He was not on the **ballot**. He was banned from public office after being convicted last year of defying decisions by the official who oversees the 1995 peace agreement. Even so, he was central to the campaign.

With nearly 90 percent of votes counted, Dodik's ally Zeljka Cvijanovic had more than 55 percent for the Serb seat on the three-member **presidency**. Dodik gave credit to U.S. President Donald Trump's 2024 **election** win and to Russian President Vladimir Putin's support. "No one should ask us to change our politics," he said.

Other candidates also claimed victory before counting was finished. Around 3.4 million people could vote. These are not final results.

Word Treasure

election -- A vote where people choose their leaders.

European Union -- A group of European countries that work together.

ethnic groups -- Groups of people who share a culture, language or ancestry.

nationalist -- A person who puts strong focus on the interests of their own nation or group.

ballot -- The list of choices voters see when they vote.

presidency -- The office of president; in Bosnia it has three members.

Break it down

Opening: Bosnia votes and what shaped the election
Dodik declares victory despite not being on the ballot
Early vote counts and Dodik's words
Other candidates and the note that results are not final

Why it matters

Bosnia's leaders are chosen by a system built after a war, so this vote shows how the country is dealing with old divisions and its hopes of joining the European Union.

Test what you remember

1. What country held the election?

- ☐ (A) Serbia
- ☐ (B) Bosnia and Herzegovina
- ☐ (C) Latvia
- ☐ (D) Brazil

2. Who declared victory for his party?

- ☐ (A) Zeljka Cvijanovic
- ☐ (B) Vladimir Putin
- ☐ (C) Milorad Dodik
- ☐ (D) Donald Trump

3. Why couldn't Dodik hold public office?

- ☐ (A) He was too young
- ☐ (B) He lost the last vote
- ☐ (C) He moved to another country
- ☐ (D) He was banned after a conviction

4. About how many votes had been counted when Cvijanovic had more than 55 percent?

- ☐ (A) All of them
- ☐ (B) Nearly 90 percent
- ☐ (C) About half
- ☐ (D) Only 10 percent

5. What does the article say about the results?

- ☐ (A) They are final
- ☐ (B) They were cancelled
- ☐ (C) They were secret
- ☐ (D) They are not final

6. About how many people could vote?

- ☐ (A) Around 34 million
- ☐ (B) Around 34 thousand
- ☐ (C) Around 340
- ☐ (D) Around 3.4 million

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):